

TEACHING TIPS:

- Lots of energetic physical warm-ups will get the children in the right mood for singing this upbeat song.
- Encourage the class to count the 4 bars of introduction (1 2 3 4, 2 2 3 4, 3 2 3 4 etc.) so that they are ready to come in in bar 5. It's good practice to do this even if you are using the Words on Screen program.
- The melody of the verse should be straightforward to learn as the second phrase is pretty much the same as the first. However, notice the difference between the rhythm for 'Hello spring' and 'lighter days'. Clap these rhythms and practise them a few times separately to ensure they are accurate.

WHAT YOU NEED

Sets of chime bars (one with C D E F G and another with C D E^b F G), large books/folders

LISTEN

Listen to some other songs in major keys, such as The Beatles' *Let It Be* or Leonard Cohen's *Hallelujah*. Now listen to some in minor keys, such as Pink Floyd's *Another Brick In The Wall* or The Beatles' *Eleanor Rigby*. Can the children suggest songs that they know and work out if they are in a major or a minor key?

PITCH

Scale – an arrangement of notes in ascending or descending order of pitch

Key – a group of notes that correspond to a certain scale and form the tonal centre of a section of music

Tonality – the harmonic effect of being in a particular key

Notation

Improvise

Sing

Listen

Play

Compose

Genre/History/Musicians

ACTIVITY

AGES 5 - 11 

Explore what makes this such a cheerful song. Children might mention the lyrics.

Discuss the contrast between winter's **dark and dreary, cold and frosty** weather and spring's **warm and lighter days, sunshine and blue skies**. Write these words up on the board in Winter and Spring columns.

Explain to the class that every piece of music is built on a **scale** or **key**, i.e. a set of notes that go up and down. In C major these notes are C D E F G A B C. All play or sing them up and down. But in C minor, two of the notes are changed – the E becomes E^b, and the A becomes A^b. Now play or sing C D E^b F G A^b B C. Can the children hear the difference? How would they describe this? Does it change the mood? **Major keys** are often described as sounding 'happy' – whereas **minor keys** can be thought of as 'sad'. Can the children hear if this song is in a major or minor key? (It's in C major.)

Set up two sets of chime bars behind a screen (some large books or folders would do). One with the notes C D E F G (a mini or 'micro' scale) and one with the notes C D E^b F G. Ask for two volunteers to improvise a short tune (starting and finishing on C) on each of the sets of chime bars. Can the rest of the class tell whether they are playing a major or a minor tune?

STEP IT UP!

Split the class into small groups, some with minor-key chime bars and some with major-key ones. Using the appropriate words from the board, and any other winter/spring words they want to add, can they **write their own Winter or Spring Song**?

WHAT'S ACHIEVABLE?

To hear the difference between major and minor keys (tonality).
To improvise a tune in a major or minor key.

To compose a short melody with lyrics in a major or minor key.

TEACHING TIPS:

- This song is guaranteed to bring a smile and **a sense of joy** to both singers and audience! It needs to be sung with loads of energy and bounce.
- Point out the **variation to the melody** on 'free as a bird' in the chorus, and enjoy how this is different to the melody of 'we're tickety-boo'.
- Notice that on the penultimate chorus, the last line 'We're full of the joys of spring!' is only sung once.

WHAT YOU NEED

Xylophones, glockenspiels or keyboards

Notation

Improvise

Sing

Listen

Play

Compose

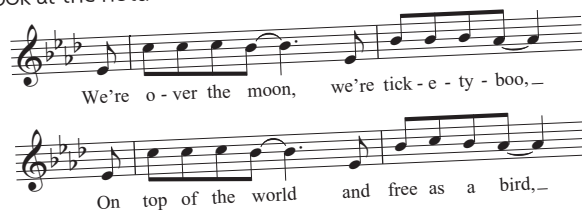
Genre/History/Musicians

ACTIVITY

AGES 7-11 

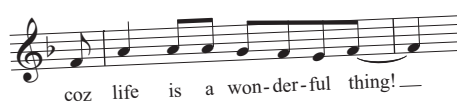
Musical variations

Look at the notation for the chorus as you play the vocal track:



Show the children how the 'free as a bird' melody has been altered or 'varied' from its first appearance on 'we're tickety-boo'. This comes as a bit of a surprise and so makes your ears prick up!

Now give out xylophones, glockenspiels or keyboards. Can they play the 'coz life is a wonderful thing' line? (Transposed into F major for ease.)



Now see if the children can **create their own variation** by changing one or more of the notes of the melody. Ask for volunteers to demonstrate their version to the class.

LISTEN

Explain that composers often write a **theme and variations**, where the main melody, harmony or instrumentation is altered to create interest. Listen to some extracts from famous classical themes and variations, e.g.

The Young Person's Guide To The Orchestra – Benjamin Britten

12 Variations on 'Ah, vous dirai-je, Maman' (also known as 'Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star') – W. A. Mozart

WHAT'S ACHIEVABLE?

- To recognize a melodic variation.
- To listen to themes and variations.
- To improvise a melodic variation.

PITCH 
How high or low a note sits

STRUCTURE 
The organization of a piece of music into sections, e.g. ABA or verse and chorus

NOTATION 
A system of written symbols used to visually represent aurally perceived music

TEACHING TIPS:

- Ask the children about the character of the song. What clues are in the music? It has a lively tempo and a cheerful tune. They might also mention the lyrics – words such as ‘perfect’, ‘beautiful’, ‘happy’, ‘haven’t got a care’.
- There is quite a lot of melodic repetition in this song which makes it easy to learn. The Words on Screen program is a brilliant aid to teaching the song line by line.
- The melody of this song contains some leaps. Practise the top B to low C in bar 5 ‘of year’ and bar 9 ‘be here’ to make sure this interval is clear and that there is no swooping down to the lower note.
- This is good song to use to try out part-singing for the first time, as the harmony part (the bridge) has already been introduced earlier in the song.

WHAT YOU NEED

Untuned percussion, sheets of paper and pens/paints

BRIGHT IDEA!

Throughout this song, the melody line of ‘Could there be a better time of year?’ is repeated ten times, with different words. Can the children **draw a rainbow in the air** with their arms every time this tune is heard?

STEP IT UP!

What other musical dimensions can you add to your graphic score? Perhaps use differently sized flowers to indicate **dynamics** – playing more quietly (*p*) or loudly (*f*).

DYNAMICS

Volume

Piano *p* – soft/quiet

Forte *f* – loud

TEXTURE

Layers of sound and rhythm

Notation

Improvise

Sing

Listen

Play

Compose

Genre/History/Musicians

ACTIVITY

AGES 4-7 

Make a graphic score!

Discuss the words of the song. What happens in spring?

Why does the song talk about ‘colours blooming everywhere’?

In groups of about three, use A3 sheets of paper and five coloured pens or paints to **create flower pictures** – have some pictures with just one flower and others with two or three, but make sure each individual flower is painted with only one colour.

With the children, choose an untuned percussion instrument to represent each colour, e.g. yellow/tambourine; orange/guero; purple/triangle etc. **Arrange the pictures** on a ‘washing line’ or wall/window to **make a score**. Follow the score using a pointer, either with the whole class or a group. The children should play their instruments (in any rhythm or style) as their coloured flower appears.

What happens when just one flower is shown? What happens when more than one flower appears on a picture?

(It will change the musical **texture**.)

WHAT'S ACHIEVABLE?

To play musical instruments while following a graphic score.

To explore dynamics.

To recognize repeated melodic patterns.

TEACHING TIPS:

- This song has a **fairly wide range**, from bottom B to high D, so make sure you warm up the whole voice before singing it. Try 'sirening' from the bottom of the range to the top, starting on a low note. Repeat the exercise, starting a semitone higher each time. Then, remember to sing the whole song with a smile!
- There are lots of **syncopated rhythms** throughout, so ensure the class can speak the words rhythmically before they sing them. Clap the pulse at the same time to highlight when the notes fall between beats e.g. 'joyful sound'.
- Focus on singing the wider **interval leaps** accurately and without swooping. For example, the perfect fifths in the chorus on 'joyful' and 'message', and the minor sixth 'of sun' in verse 1 (and subsequent verses).

WHAT YOU NEED

Internet connection; pitched and unpitched percussion instruments; imagination!

LISTEN

The composer Olivier Messiaen was crazy about birdsong! He spent over four decades studying and notating it and composed numerous pieces using it as his inspiration. *Reveil d'Oiseaux* (Dawn Chorus) is a piece for piano and orchestra that contains songs from 38 different French birds. Messiaen was a devout Roman Catholic and believed that birdsong was a direct link to the music of heaven.

RHYTHM

Duration/length of notes; regular, repeated patterns of sound

Syncopation – placement of notes off the main beat

Motif – a musical figure (usually rhythmic or melodic) used to represent a character, mood or place

DYNAMICS

Volume

Crescendo – a gradual increase in volume and intensity

Diminuendo – a gradual decrease in volume and intensity

PITCH

How high or low a note sits

Interval – the difference in pitch between two sounds

TIMBRE

The character or quality of a musical sound

Notation

Sing

Improvise

Listen

Play

Compose

Genre/History/Musicians

ACTIVITY

AGES 7 - 11 

Brilliant Birdsong!

As a class, listen to some birdsong (www.british-birdsongs.uk is a great site to look at for this) and identify ones that you could simulate using percussion instruments or vocal sounds. (If you have any instrumentalists amongst you, see if they could use their instruments for this.) Focus particularly on the **timbre, pitch and rhythms of the different bird calls**.

Having chosen your birds, **create a number of different birdsong motifs**. Remember, you don't need to *copy* each bird call, but use it as *inspiration* for your motif, e.g. you might choose a chaffinch call and use a tambourine to tap at first then shake, starting quietly, with a crescendo through the taps and diminuendo through the shake; or use a sand tube to create the call of a barn owl.

Once your motifs are created, work as a group to **improvise a brilliant birdsong composition**. Choose a 'caller' to start the piece by setting the scene. They can call out the weather, time of day, season and location, for example, 'It's a sunny morning in spring in the Yorkshire Dales.'

As you improvise, make sure you watch each other and visually communicate when someone should play next, join in, or sit out.

You might want to select a leader for this, but working as a team is good too.

WHAT'S ACHIEVABLE?

To begin to define and recognize a range of timbres.

To compose motifs using appropriate timbres and dynamics on instruments.

To perform an improvised composition in ensemble, communicating with fellow musicians.

TEACHING TIPS:

- Warm up the facial muscles ready to sing using exaggerated 'chewing' and 'munching' actions.
- Notice how the melody moves mainly by leaps, but then descends by steps (a **scale**) in bars 7 and 11. Indicating these intervals in the air with your hand flat in front of you will help your singers to pitch the intervals correctly.
- Try getting the children to raise their eyebrows (or caterpillars!) to help get their voices up to the high Cs in bars 5 and 9.
- Invent some actions for each verse to help them remember the different words, but don't make them too complicated, or they may forget to sing!

WHAT YOU NEED

Pitched and unpitched percussion instruments

BRIGHT IDEA!

What time of year is it? Is the weather warm or cold? Think about how you can make warm sounds (wooden instruments played softly) or cold sounds (metallic instruments played more loudly)?

STEP IT UP!

Try varying the dynamics to create contrast between the different verses of the song. Play '**guess the dynamic**' with one group of children performing either very softly (**pp**), softly (**p**), moderately loudly (**mf**) and very loudly (**ff**) – without shouting or straining their voices!). Can the other group guess the dynamic?

RHYTHM

Pulse – the beat, or steady heartbeat of the music

PITCH

Scale – an arrangement of notes in ascending or descending order of pitch

TIMBRE

The character or quality of a musical sound

Tone colour of instruments: low/high; soft/hard; metallic/wooden/stringed/wind

DYNAMICS

Volume

Notation

Improvise

Sing

Listen

Play

Compose

Genre/History/Musicians

ACTIVITY

AGES
4 - 7



This song has a strong four-beats-in-a-bar **pulse**. Talk about what a pulse is (like a heartbeat or a ticking clock). To help the class to 'feel' the pulse, see if they can march on the spot or around the classroom in time to the music. Can they now 'creep and crawl', still keeping to the beat?

Try adding some simple unpitched percussion, e.g. guiros and woodblocks, to emphasize the pulse. They could play on all four beats of the bar, or as a challenge, just beats two and four, e.g. sh tap sh tap. What is the song about? Listen carefully to the words. Is there a story? Listen carefully to the backing track and see if you can pick out the different instruments and sounds that might relate to this – which sounds represent the caterpillar, and which the butterfly? Think about other sounds that you might hear in a garden, e.g. the wind in the trees, bees buzzing, birds singing etc. How might you reflect those sounds with instruments from your classroom instrument box?

WHAT'S ACHIEVABLE?

To begin to internalize pitch and pulse.
To begin to recognize a range of timbres.
To explore how different timbres can be used to create sound effects and imagery.

TEACHING TIPS:

- This is a great song to **cheer everyone up** on a rainy day! Each of the four parts is easy to learn and will sound impressive sung altogether.
- Teach all the parts to everyone first before splitting the class into four groups and **allocating each a verse**. You might like to have equally-sized groups or small groups for verses 1-3 and a larger group for verse 4 – it's up to you.
- Encourage the children to listen carefully to the track to help them know when to come in. At first it will be helpful to **conduct the entries**.
- Make sure that the verse 1 singers put the 'p' on the end of each 'drip, drop' and remember to watch the conductor for their final line, 'we've gotta stop'.
- You might like to try singing without the backing track and **experimenting** with the groups starting and stopping at different times.
- A performance with children wearing wellies and raincoats, and some **choreography** involving umbrellas, would be great fun!

WHAT YOU NEED

Percussion instruments e.g. xylophones, rainmakers, shakers

LOOK

For **more inspiration** for your rainy-day soundscape, have a look at this fun body-percussion soundscape by Perpetuum Jazzile:

www.youtube.com/watch?v=c3LjvUzxm5E

Or try this simple version with the class:

www.youtube.com/watch?v=xgKy1gCugKY

Talk about the different **timbres**, **dynamics** and **textures** that are produced.

TIMBRE

The character or quality of a musical sound

TEXTURE

Layers of rhythm and sound

DYNAMICS

Volume

Notation

Improvise

Sing

Listen

Play

Compose

Genre/History/Musicians

ACTIVITY

AGES 5-7 

Rainy-day percussion

Discuss how you could **represent rain sounds** using percussion instruments and body percussion. Would metallic or wooden instruments sound best? Can the children make a 'drip' sound with their mouths, as if they were fish? You might like to listen to the backing track on its own for inspiration.

As a class, decide which instruments/sounds (timbres) would be best for each verse. As a starting point, you could try the following:

Verse 1: mouths

Verse 2: fingers patting on desks

Verse 3: xylophones playing the 'it's raining, it's pouring' motif using the notes C A F

Verse 4: rainmakers and shakers for 'April showers'

Try performing along with the vocal track, or splitting the class in half and having half singing, half playing.

WHAT'S ACHIEVABLE?

To explore texture and timbre.

To perform in four parts as an ensemble.

To improvise a percussive accompaniment.

TEACHING TIPS:

- There are lots of words in this song that all need to be sung clearly, so **start with a warm-up that focuses on diction** such as *Peter Piper* from *Sing Warm-Ups*.
- Try to keep the tempo steady and avoid rushing, especially through the faster words.
- Notice that the quavers in the melody are performed 'swung', i.e. with the first quaver lengthened and the second quaver shortened. This is indicated above the score by (♩ = ♪♪) and gives the song its distinctive jazzy feel.

WHAT YOU NEED

Pencils and paper (optional)

LISTEN

For inspiration, listen to the beginning of *The Geographical Fugue* by Ernst Toch. Can they hear each of the four vocal parts or 'layers' come in? Listen out for the accented 'Trinidad' each time.

STEP IT UP!

This song features a key change or **modulation** up a semitone at the beginning of verse 4. Lots of popular songs do this to increase the excitement/intensity towards the end of a song. Listen to *Penny Lane* by The Beatles, *Living on a Prayer* by Bon Jovi, *Perfect Illusion* by Lady Gaga, *Man in the Mirror* by Michael Jackson, the list goes on and on! Can the class identify when the key change occurs and stand up as they hear it?

PITCH

Modulation – the change from one key (tonal centre) to another

Sequence – a repetition of a phrase or melody at a higher or lower pitch

DYNAMICS

Volume

TEXTURE

Layers of sound and rhythm

Notation

Improvise

Sing

Listen

Play

Compose

Genre/History/Musicians

ACTIVITY

AGES 7-11



Explore the lyrics 'the buds

are busy blossoming and blooming', 'it's a bright and breezy, nice and easy feeling', 'daffodils-as-far-as-you-can-see thing', 'skip-along-the-road-and-hum-a-tune thing', 'feather-duster-whistle-while-you're-cleaning' and 'creepy-caterpillar-buzzy-bee thing'.

Speak them rhythmically, as they are sung in the song, and at different dynamic levels e.g. loudly, moderately loudly, quietly. Split the class into small groups. To keep in time, have one group as a steady crotchet pulse repeating 'buds are blooming' over and over. Another group then repeats 'the buds are busy blossoming and blooming' rhythmically over the top. A third group can then add another phrase or 'layer' to the texture, e.g. 'it's a bright and breezy, nice and easy feeling'.

Then ask each group to **compose a 'spoken chorus' or rap**, using some or all of these phrases, lasting between 30 seconds and a minute. They will need to think about how many times each phrase is repeated, varying the texture by using solos and/or duet sections, dynamics, the ensemble skills of coming in together (perhaps having a conductor) and staying in time. They may need to write down who does what and when! They could also include body percussion such as stamping, clapping or clicking fingers as a pulse to help them keep to the beat. Can they perform their compositions to the class?

WHAT'S ACHIEVABLE?

To explore texture in music.

To begin to develop creative thinking through composition.

To perform a 'spoken chorus' or rap, in time as an ensemble.

TEACHING TIPS:

- In your warm-up, **focus on breathing** to help sustain the lyrical melody in this song.
- The chorus should be positive and punchy, sung with lots of energy. Be sure to separate and emphasize important lyrics such as 'God is good to us' so they can be heard. Contrast this in the verses with a **legato** sound and use good breath control to make sure the long C (on 'change' in verse 1) is held for its full four beats.
- As the melody goes quite low in the register in the chorus (on 'You are faithful God'/'We are grateful Lord'), be careful not to let these words die away too much – good breath support is important here.

WHAT YOU NEED

Tuned instruments e.g. glockenspiels (pre-prepared to include only the notes C D E G A); note cards or black/white board

LISTEN

Drones are used in all genres of music, including medieval, classical, popular and folk music. Try listening to the opening of John Adams's *Shaker Loops 1* or some Scottish bagpipe music, in which a low drone is always clearly heard.

STEP IT UP!

Using the letter names, see if the children can write out their melodies on strips of paper. Encourage them to add other details like **tempo** – is it fast, slow or something in between? Write this at the beginning of the 'score' – and **dynamics** (*ff*, *f*, *mf*, *mp*, *p*, *pp*). Some children might be able to try using standard music notation to write out the notes of their melodies.

DYNAMICS

Volume

TEMPO

The speed of the music

Notation

Improvise

Sing

Listen

Play

Compose

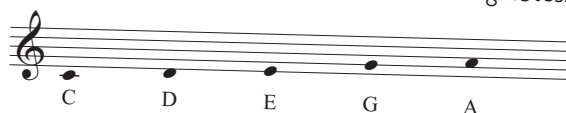
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ACTIVITY

AGES 7-11 

If you listen really carefully to the chorus you might notice that it mainly has the same bass note in the piano – B^b – and only briefly strays to other nearby notes. This is called a **tonic** (the first note of the scale), **pedal note** or **root note** and reinforces the key of the song (B^b major). It can often be used as a **drone** which plays continuously beneath a melody. Using pitched percussion instruments or keyboards and working in pairs, ask the class to **compose their own simple melodies over a drone in the bass**.

To do this, use a **pentatonic scale** starting on C. Give the children the notes C D E G A to choose from (write the note names and standard notation on cards or on the board) and remind them to use short and long notes.



It will sound best if the melody starts and finishes on C (the tonic of this scale). One pupil plays the melody while their partner plays the C drone.

Then swap over.

WHAT'S ACHIEVABLE?

- To compose a short pentatonic melody above a drone.
- To begin to use standard notation to record a composition.
- To sing a song with harmony parts.

PITCH

Tonic – the first note of a major or minor scale

Drone – a continuous musical note, often of low pitch

Pentatonic scale – a five-note scale pattern

TEACHING TIPS:

- This is a **bouncy**, happy song, so try to reflect this in your singing style, particularly in the verses.
- Contrast this with a smoother, more **lyrical style** on 'spring has sprung', 'blooming bright' and 'new has come' in the choruses.
- Watch out for the **syncopated rhythm** on 'they're' and 'me' in verse 1 (and in the corresponding places in verses 2 and 3).
- Notice there's no 'And' on the penultimate line of verse 3, which is different to earlier in the verse – so it's just 'Everywhere 'round us there's life to be found'.

WHAT YOU NEED

A good sense of pulse; untuned percussion e.g. claves, guiros, shakers

LISTEN

Listen to the bass line played by the left hand of the pianist in *New Orleans Blues* by Jelly Roll Morton, which features the tresillo rhythm.
www.youtube.com/watch?v=k24fD36Zurk

LOOK

For more about the origin of the 'tresillo' rhythm and some more contemporary examples, watch www.youtube.com/watch?v=DZ_yT_ukKKA&t=53s. It's a bit long to play in its entirety but you might want to play some short clips to the children.

Notation

Improvise

Sing

Listen

Play

Compose

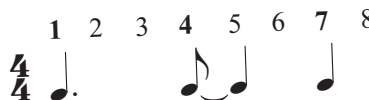
Genre/History/Musicians

ACTIVITY

AGES 7-11 

Syncopated percussion

Listen carefully to the backing track. See if the children can clap along with the following **syncopated rhythm**, which emphasizes quaver beats 1, 4 and 7 of the bar:



This is also known as a 3 + 3 + 2 or 'tresillo' rhythm, which is the rhythm that gets your toes tapping and hips swaying in Latin American music. See if the children can gently move from one foot to the other on beats 1 and 3 of the bar (or beats 1 and 5 if you are counting in quavers) as they clap along with the track.

Now transfer this rhythm to various untuned percussion instruments such as claves, guiros and shakers to **create a rhythmic accompaniment** to the verses of the song.

WHAT'S ACHIEVABLE?

To explore tresillo rhythm.
To clap along in time with the song.
To perform a percussion accompaniment.

RHYTHM

Duration/length of notes; regular, repeated patterns of sound

TEXTURE

Layers of rhythm and sound

TEACHING TIPS:

- Talk about the **lyrics** to this song. What is happening to the tadpole?
- Can you make up some **actions** to help remember what happens in each verse?
- The whole song is made up of short one-and-a-half or two-bar phrases, which makes it easy to learn. Teach the song using **call-and-response** and if you use Words on Screen (WOS) then take advantage of the double-click line function.
- Choose a small group of strong singers to do the chorus harmonies. If you can, play or sing through each of the parts individually to help the singers learn their line, or even better, use the WOS which will play each harmony part for you.
- Be prepared for, and enjoy, the backing track 'stop' when you sing the word 'tadpole'.

WHAT YOU NEED

Recording of *Carnival of the Animals*, pictures of orchestral instruments; pitched and unpitched instruments

BRIGHT IDEA

If space allows, can they move around to the music in the style of the animals?

STEP IT UP!

Compose some short animal pieces. In small groups, choose an animal and discuss its characteristics. Will the music be loud or soft, fast or slow, low- or high-pitched, and which instruments will best represent the animal? Use pitched and unpitched percussion, keyboards, or any instruments that you are able to play. Then, encourage the children to imagine they are telling a story in order to give the music a structure. What is happening to the animal? Are they asleep, on the prowl, playing? What will their music need to do to show this? Ask each group to announce their animal to the class before they perform their piece.

TEMPO

The speed of the music

DYNAMICS

Volume

TIMBRE

The character or quality of a musical sound

Notation

Improvise

Sing

Listen

Play

Compose

Genre/History/Musicians

ACTIVITY

AGES 5-7

Many composers have been inspired to write **music about animals**. One of the most famous pieces is *Carnival of the Animals*, a suite for two pianos and orchestral instruments by Camille Saint-Saëns. Discuss the instruments of the orchestra (show some pictures) and then write the list of the movements from this piece up on the board. Play the children a few of them and see if they can guess which animal is represented each time.

What clues are given in the music? Listen out for:

- Whether the music is loud or soft (**dynamics**)
- Which instrumentation the composer has chosen to use – piano, strings, woodwind, brass, percussion? (**timbre**)
- What speed is the music – is it slow or fast? (**tempo**)

For example:

- **The Royal March of the Lion** – the music is loud, proud and stately. About halfway through the piano plays a chromatic scale in the bass (this is then echoed by the lower strings), which is the lions growling!
- **Tortoises** – the music is slow and plodding with the tune in the bass (lower strings).
- **Kangaroos** – The melody 'jumps' around the piano!
- **The Swan** – The gentle broken chords in the piano depict the rippling water with the cello representing the swan gliding serenely through it.

WHAT'S ACHIEVABLE?

To listen to and identify different timbres and instrumentation.

To create a composition that tells a story, using sound imagery.

To perform as a group.

TEACHING TIPS:

- This is a catchy, fun song. Encourage the children to **smile** and look at each other and their audience (real or imaginary!) as they sing.
- Throughout the song, the voices need to enter on the second beat of the bar. Practise this so no one is caught by surprise! (It will be easier to breathe in the previous bar rather than try to snatch a breath during the crotchet rest on the first beat.)
- Make sure the **syncopation** on 'savoury or sweet', 'such a special treat' and elsewhere is accurate.
- For variety and added musicality, try out different dynamics for each verse.

WHAT YOU NEED

Percussion instruments



Notation

Improvise

Sing

Listen

Play

Compose

Genre/History/Musicians

DID YOU KNOW?



Polyrhythm (like the overlapping rhythms you've created with your cool percussion accompaniment) and **syncopation** occur in a lot of music from around the world – Indian music, Afro-Cuban music, jazz, hip hop, metal, and even Western classical and popular music.

ACTIVITY

AGES 7-11



The introduction of this song is rhythmic and syncopated with a laid-back jazz feel.

Using percussion instruments, **compose a cool jazz-club-style accompaniment to the song**. Split into three groups and allocate each a set of instruments (e.g. shakers, cabasas, guiros, congas and bongos). First, establish a steady pulse, perhaps by walking on the spot, clapping or patting the chest or knees, so everyone really 'feels' the vibe.

Drums

tas - ty top - pings, but

Shakers/cabasas

eat them while they're hot,

Guiros

eat them while they're hot,

Then clap the rhythms on the left, making sure each group is really secure with their rhythm before transferring it to the instruments.

Repeat each rhythm as an **ostinato** throughout the song, first using just the backing track, and then adding the voices. Make sure the accompanying musicians are sensitive to the singers and don't drown them out!

RHYTHM



Syncopation – placement of notes off the main beat

Polyrhythm – the simultaneous use of two or more different rhythms

Ostinato – repeated rhythmic or melodic pattern

BRIGHT IDEA



Try making your own percussion instruments using **everyday kitchen objects** such as saucepan lids, frying pans, sieves and wooden spoons. If anyone has an old washboard knocking about it will make a perfect guiro!

WHAT'S ACHIEVABLE?



To explore polyrhythm.
To create and perform an ostinato as an accompaniment.

TEACHING TIPS:

- There are lots of words in this song that all need to be sung clearly, so **start with a warm-up that focuses on diction** such as *Peter Piper* from *Sing Warm-Ups*.
- There is lots of nice easy stepwise movement in this melody, but the occasional semitones will need practice, e.g. notice the difference between the notes of the first 'It's a good' in bar 4 and the 'it's a good' in bar 8.
- Help the children to know when to come in at the end of the first time bar. Listen out for two upbeats in the brass and then come in with 'It's a' on the third one.

WHAT YOU NEED

A good sense of pulse

LOOK

There are some amazing examples of body percussion to watch online. Try looking up **THE PERCUSSION SHOW** body percussion on YouTube for starters.

RHYTHM



Pulse – the beat, or steady heartbeat of the music

Rest – a period of silence of a specified duration

Call & response – a musical phrase in which the first melody or rhythm is responded to or echoed by another melody or rhythm

BRIGHT IDEA



In a circle, tapping the pulse on the knees, all sing 'It's a good time to tell you, I love you Mum'. Now replace 'you Mum' with other words suggested by the children such as **'baked beans', 'football', 'my dog'** etc. They'll need to think of two-syllable phrases. Do a few together to get the idea. Then go around the circle and point to a volunteer (sitting with their hand raised) who would like to sing their suggestion while everyone else keeps the pulse going. This game encourages confidence and singing in time.

WHAT'S ACHIEVABLE?



- To keep a steady pulse.
- To explore rests in music.
- To listen to a rhythm and clap it back (call and response).
- To begin to sing confidently and in time.

Notation

Improvise

Sing

Listen

Play

Compose

Genre/History/Musicians

ACTIVITY

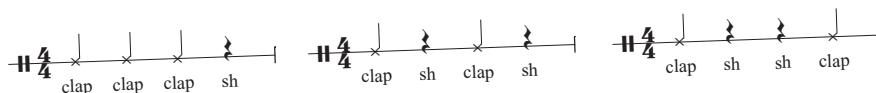
AGES 4-7



First, listen to the song and feel its strong **four-beat pulse** by clapping or tapping along, saying **1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4** with emphasis on the 1 each time (perhaps add a stamp on this beat).

Now, listen carefully to the melody line. Explain that a **rest** is a period of silence in a piece of music (not a time for lying down!). **Can the class identify where there are rests in the music?** To demonstrate this, say 'sh' with a finger to the lips in each of the rests. Sometimes there will be one 'sh' (a one-beat rest e.g. after 'I love you Mum' and 'you're the best') and sometimes two (a two-beat rest e.g. after 'best mum for me!').

Sitting or standing in a circle, have half the class keeping the pulse steady by tapping their knees. Clap some four-beat rhythms with rests in, for the other half of the class to copy. Then swap over groups. For example:



With older or more confident pupils, each could clap their response individually. Can the children say which beat of the bar the rest was on? Would one pupil like to lead by clapping a 'rest rhythm' for the others to copy?

TEACHING TIPS:

- This song is a great introduction to singing in harmony.
- The different verses have some big **vocal jumps** in the melody. Make sure voices are warmed up properly to help sing these leaps cleanly. Begin by making a siren sound, going up high and down low. This will help warm up the vocal cords. Then, try using a warm-up like *Ear Warm* from *Sing Warm-ups*.
- As an introduction to pitching **intervals**, sing up a scale using the numbers 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8, then back down 8 7 6 5 4 3 2 1. Then try an arpeggio 1 3 5 3 1. Then try other permutations e.g. 1 2 1 3 1 4 1 5 1 6 1 7 1 8.

WHAT YOU NEED



Pieces of paper labelled with letter names of a C major scale; keyboards (notes C-C with stickers on) or pitched percussion (notes C-C)

BRIGHT IDEA



Can the children think of and **identify any intervals** outside of the classroom, for example a door bell, a cuckoo, a mobile phone ringtone, the first four notes of the Star Wars Theme, the call 'yoo hoo'? **Musical intervals are all around us!**

PITCH



How high or low a note sits
Interval – the difference in pitch between two sounds

Scale – an arrangement of notes in ascending or descending order of pitch

Notation

Improvise

Sing

Listen

Play

Compose

Genre/History/Musicians

ACTIVITY

AGES
7 - 11



Musical Ladders!

The melody of this song has some big leaps in it. The musical distance (leap) from one note to another is called an **interval**. Try this activity to practise counting intervals and playing them to **see what they sound like**.

Place eight pieces of paper in a vertical line on the floor and label them: C D E F G A B C. This is your 'musical ladder' or **scale**. Ask two volunteers to stand on two of the 'notes'. Count and sing up the steps between the two notes to find the musical interval. Remember to include the start and end notes in your count (e.g. D-A would be a **fifth**, and E-F would be a **second**).

When you have identified the interval, ask the class to play it using keyboards or pitched percussion instruments such as glockenspiels, xylophones or chime bars. Can they try singing the intervals, with one person singing the bottom note and the other singing the top one?

WHAT'S ACHIEVABLE?



To hear the difference between musical intervals.

To identify, play and sing musical intervals.

TEACHING TIPS:

- As much of this song is in a low register, ensure the children aren't tempted to 'belt' it out or shout, and use lots of support when moving into head voice for the higher notes at the end of the verses ('power and resurrection').
- The rhythm of the words in the first and fifth lines of each verse will need careful practice. Speak them a couple of times first, in rhythm, before singing them.
- Listen to the use of **dynamics** at the end of the song, during the 'We're coming alive' section. Encourage your singers to make the most of this gradual and spine-tingling **crescendo**.

WHAT YOU NEED

Pitched percussion and/or keyboards

LISTEN

At the end of this song, there is a repeated lyric, 'We're coming alive!'. Listen to **After The Rain (1983) by Frank Denyer**. The composer was inspired to write this from "experiencing the astonishing transformation of an area of semi-desert, when, after a sustained period of drought, a modest shower totally transformed the barren landscape in a very short time into one exploding with life." Denyer's use of sound and instrumentation could inspire similar class compositions on this theme.

DID YOU KNOW?

Bells are among the **oldest and simplest** musical instruments in the world, used throughout many of the world's religions – from Anglican church bells to Shintoist and Buddhist bells. In Roman Catholicism, bells symbolize the voice of God, and are used to call people to worship, as well as for ceremonies such as weddings and funerals. In Russian Orthodoxy, enormous bells are used to directly address God.

TEMPO

The speed of the music

PITCH

How high or low a note sits
Scale – an arrangement of notes in ascending or descending order of pitch

DYNAMICS

Crescendo – a gradual increase in volume

Notation

Improvise

Sing

Listen

Play

Compose

Genre/History/Musicians

ACTIVITY

AGES 7 - 11



Listen carefully to the backing track, particularly the introduction. Can the class hear the bell-like sounds? Now listen to the melody. Can they hear any phrases that might sound like bells? The **descending scale** in bar 8 'Shout it from the rooftops' sounds a bit like a **peal of church bells**. Remind the class that a scale is a set of notes that go up and down. Can the children play this 'micro' scale of D major (as it is only 6 notes rather than 8) on keyboards, chime bars or glockenspiels?



(If you don't have sets of the above notes use the scale of C but starting at A: A G F E D C. You will get the same effect.)

Can they play the scale together as a class, with each note sounding at the same time? You will need to count them in and keep to a steady pulse. Now, split the class into two groups and have the second group start their scale slightly after the first group, like a round. Decide how many times you are going to repeat the scale. Split into further groups, with each group starting their scale in turn, but overlapping with the other groups. The effect should be something similar to pealing bells. **Experiment with the tempo** i.e. have some groups performing their scale faster and others slower.

WHAT'S ACHIEVABLE?

To play the notes of a 'micro' scale.

To perform a scale as a round, in groups.

TEACHING TIPS:

- The best way to learn this song is to **listen to it** a good few times. Put it on in the background as you work on some creative Easter crafts and you'll find when you come to sing it, so much is already embedded.
- It can be easy to go out of tune (flat) when singing a downward phrase such as 'He is risen! Love is here' and 'Hallelujah'. To encourage the children to 'think' upwards as they sing down, ask them to raise their arms in front of them, as if lifting the air.
- Make sure that the long notes on 'Je-sus' in bars 32-33, and again in the final two bars, are held for their full lengths, and that everybody comes off together so that there are no hissing snakes on the final 's'!

Notation Improvise
Sing Listen

Play

Compose

Genre/History/Musicians

WHAT YOU NEED

Your body!

DID YOU KNOW?

Lots of **nursery rhymes** are written with a $\frac{6}{8}$ time signature: *Hickory Dickory Dock*, *Hey Diddle Diddle*, *Humpty Dumpty*, *Pop Goes The Weasel*, *Ring A Ring O' Roses*. Do the class know any of these? Could they incorporate any rhythms from these songs into their body percussion pieces?

ACTIVITY

AGES
7-11

This song

is in a $\frac{6}{8}$ **time signature**. Listen to the backing track (the second verse onwards, when the drums come in, will be easiest) and ask the children to clap or step along to the beat (**pulse**) of the music. Some children may clap a slow pulse (two dotted crotchet beats per bar) and others may clap quickly (with six quaver beats per bar). $\frac{6}{8}$ is known as a **compound time signature** because, most commonly, each bar is divided into two beats of three quavers.

Now, split the class into two groups and have one clap the quaver pulse with a slight accent on the first quaver (1 2 3 4 5 6) and the other clap the dotted crotchets (1-and-a 2-and-a). Now swap over. Can they 'stamp' or move from one foot to the other in a dotted-crotchet pulse, whilst clapping the quavers? Now, try tapping the quaver beats on the left leg, and the dotted crotchet pulse on the right leg. (Or tap with both hands on a desk top if you prefer.) Now swap over hands.

This is tricky, but good for the brain!

RHYTHM



Pulse – the beat, or steady heartbeat of the music

Time signature – an indication of rhythm/metre which gives the number of beats per bar

Compound time signature – where strong beats are subdivided by three rather than two

Crotchet $\frac{1}{4}$ – a musical note with a time value equal to two quavers

Quaver $\frac{1}{8}$ – a musical note with a time value equal to half a crotchet

Dotted crotchet $\frac{3}{8}$ – a musical note with a time value equal to one and a half crotchets

STEP IT UP



Introduce one other common $\frac{6}{8}$ rhythm (crotchet, quaver, crotchet, quaver). In small groups, using their three rhythms, can the class make up a piece of **body percussion**? Use stamping, clapping, tapping, patting the knees, clicking fingers – anything goes, as long as it is rhythmic and in time!



WHAT'S ACHIEVABLE?

To begin to understand the construction of a $\frac{6}{8}$ time signature.

To internalize a $\frac{6}{8}$ pulse.

To improvise a piece of body percussion in $\frac{6}{8}$.